



NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

VOID DISPATCH

Void Dispatch is a zine about cities, infrastructure, and the systems we live inside. Free to read. Free to print. Free to leave somewhere.

Contributing writers: Dana Ferris, M. Okafor, T. Nakamura, S. Reyes, P. Voss.

Printed on whatever you have.

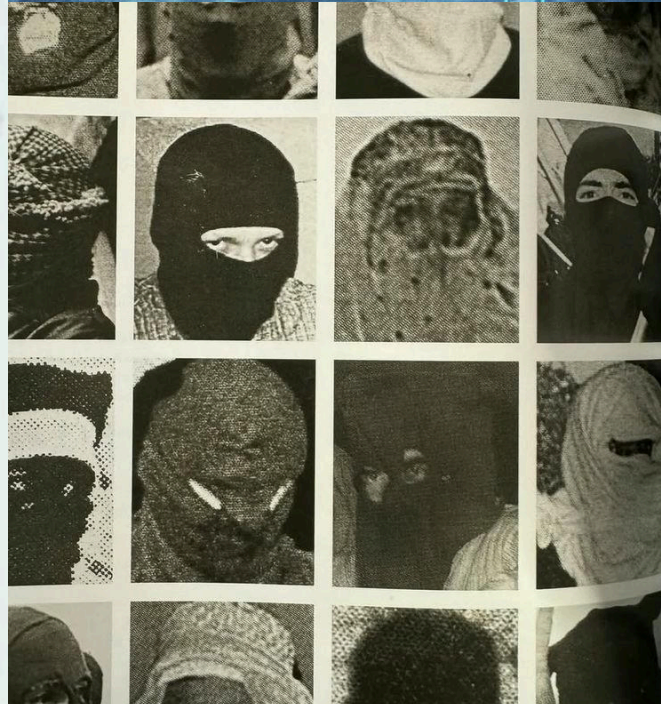
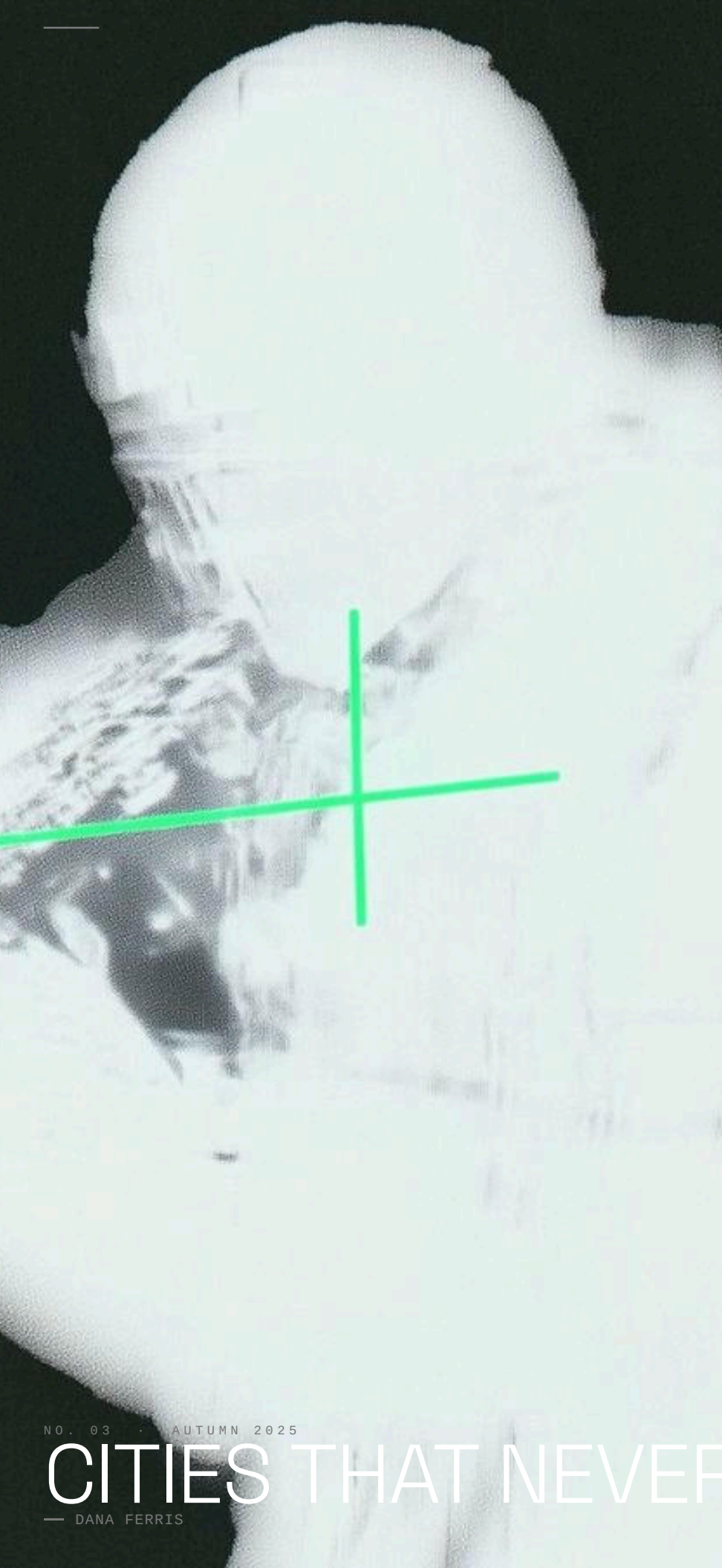
void-dispatch @ proton.me



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VOID DISPATCH

- 1 _____ CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP
 - 2 _____ THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR
 - 3 _____ THE LAST PAYPHONE
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CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP

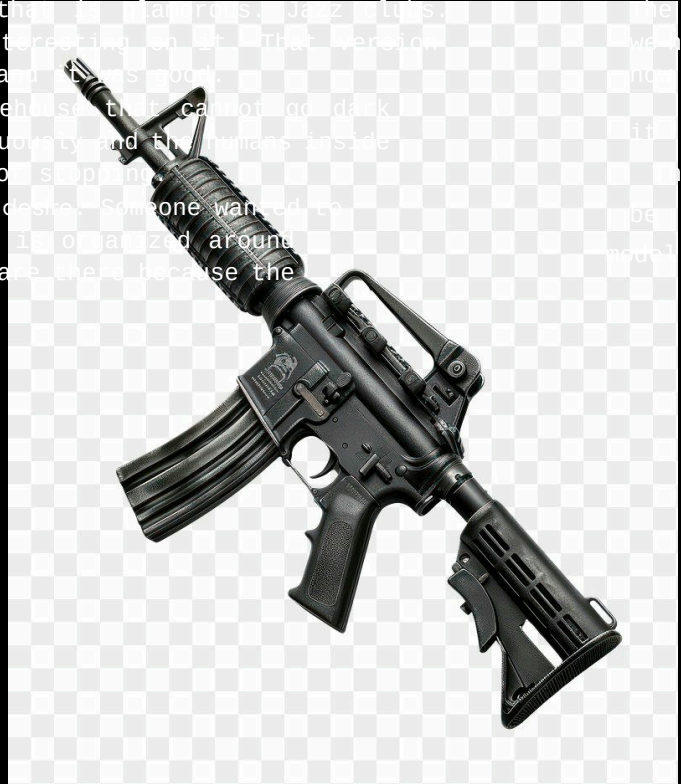
— DANA FERRIS

-- ARTICLE

CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP

— DANA FERRIS

There is a version of the 24-hour city that is glamorous. Jazz clubs. Diners. The last bus home and someone interesting on it. That version existed, briefly, in a handful of places, and it is gone. The version that is different. It is **logistics**. It is a warehouse that cannot go dark because the sortation algorithm runs continuously and the humans inside are cheaper than the reconfiguration cost of stopping it. The romantic 24-hour city was organized around desire. Someone wanted to be there at 3am. The logistical 24-hour city is organized around throughput. No one wants to be there. They are there because the system requires it.



"/ "FULFILLMENT CENTER, OUTER RING ROAD

QUOTE

The lights are always on here. That used to mean something.

— OUTSIDE A FULFILLMENT CENTER, 3:14AM



This is the distinction that city planners, when they try to make "vibrancy," consistently fail to make. Vibrancy is not a property of illuminated windows. It is a property of people choosing to be somewhere. We built infrastructure for the night and called it night life. We built coverage for every hour and called it community. We lit every corner and called it safety. None of these substitutions are neutral.

A city that cannot sleep is not
awake. It is running a process.

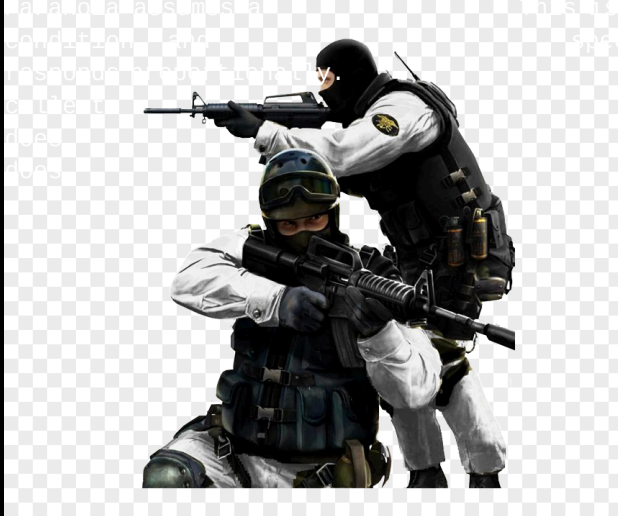


NOVEMBER 2025

THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR

ARTICLE THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR

— M. OKAFOR



"/ "ANALOG, UNCONNECTED

Method two: reduce identity surface area. You have more accounts than you need. Some are attached to your phone number, a payment method, a device fingerprint. reduction is not deactivation. It is to stop creating ones. Every new account is a new exposure surface.

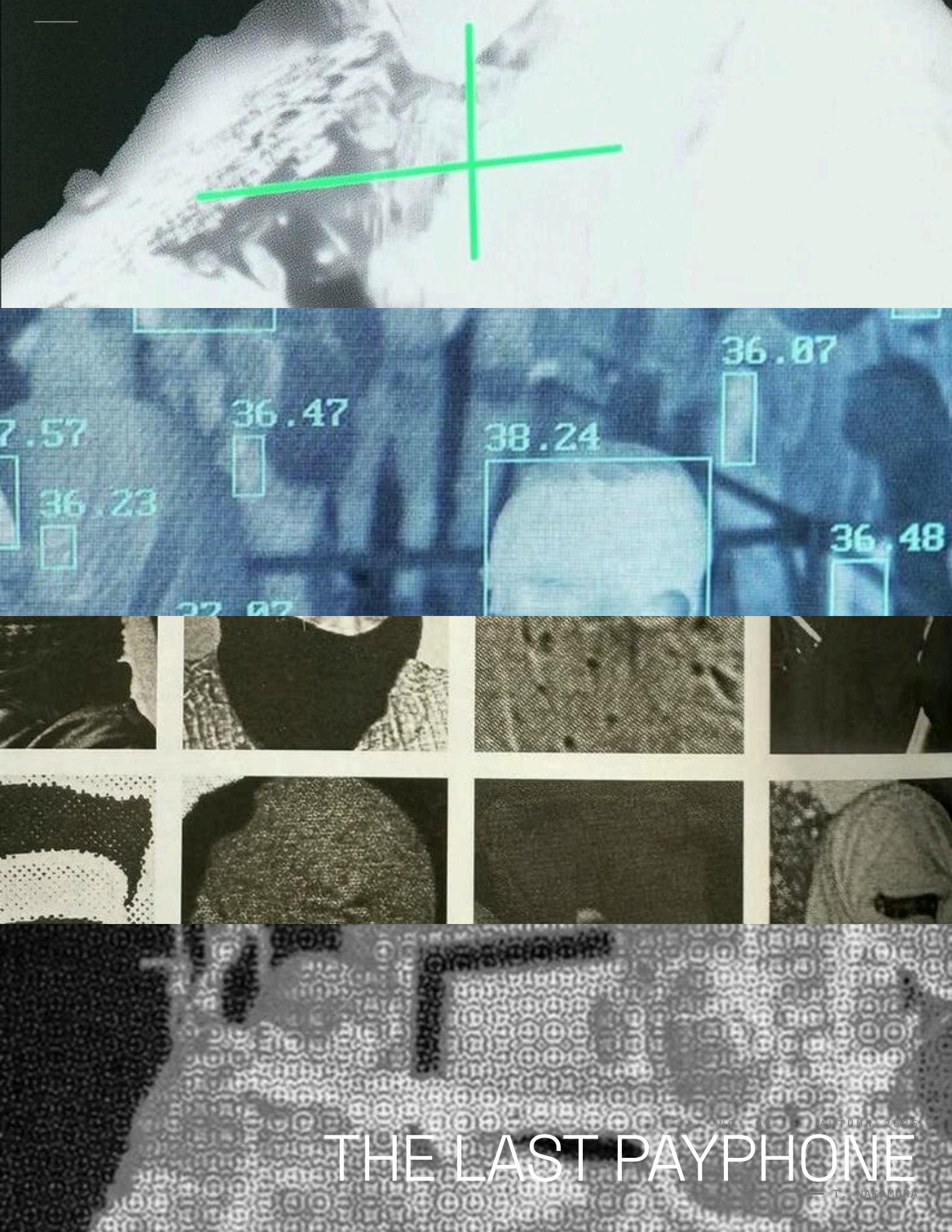
Method three: make boring choices visible. Notice when you make a choice. Not every choice requires a different decision. But many defaults were set by someone whose choice was not yours. Default on: location sharing, analytics, tracking, personalized ads. Reversing these – not just reversing them – changes what flows through the pipes.

not a paranoia piece. This is a practice piece. Specific adversary. Practice assumes a general **Method one: go analog for the boring stuff.** Most surveillance is passive and opportunistic. It whatever flows through the pipes. A notebook not have a privacy policy. A pocket calendar not sync to a data broker. Shopping lists, personal notes, appointments with people you trust – none of these need a network.



THE ACTUAL THREAT MODEL

You are probably not being targeted specifically. You are in a database being queried by systems with no opinion about you as a person. The goal is not to escape the database. The goal is to make the query less useful.



THE LAST PAYPHONE

MAY 2005 / AUTUMN 2005

— T. NAKAMURA

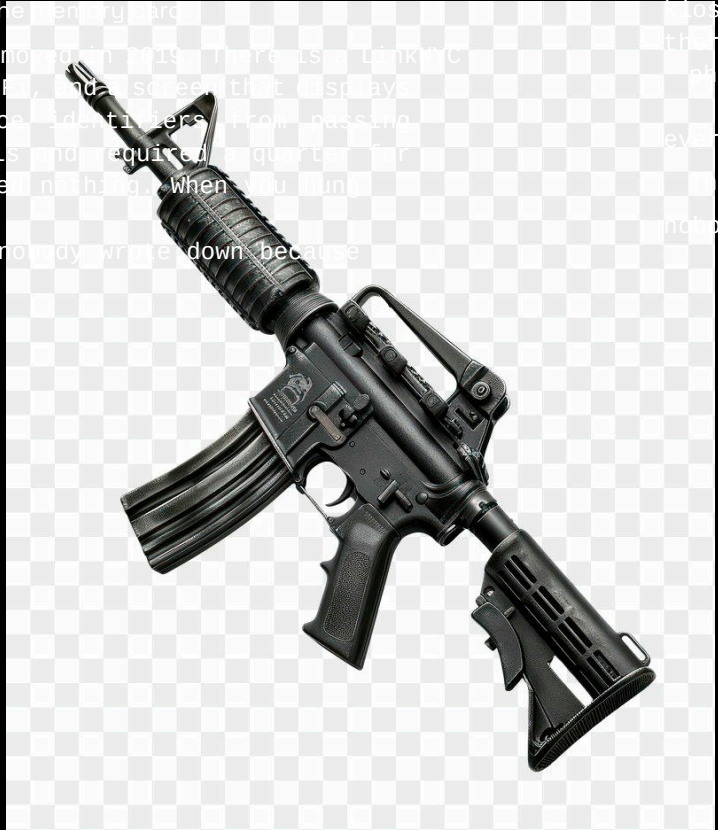
-- ARTICLE

THE LAST PAYPHONE

— T. NAKAMURA

A photo essay without photos, because we lost the emergency card.

The payphone on Delancey and Essex was removed in 2019. There is a LinkNYC kiosk now. The kiosk offers free calls, fast Wi-Fi, and also see that last day advertisements. It also collects device identifiers from passing phones. The payphone offered free emergency calls and required no quarter for anything else. It collected nothing. It remembered nothing. When you hung up, the conversation was over. It was not a bug. This was a feature that nobody wrote down because they thought it would need to be defended.



"/ "DELANCEY AND ESSEX, 2019

QUOTE

You could call anyone and they couldn't call you back unless they already knew where you were.

— A PERSON WHO REMEMBERED THE QUARTER



The last payphone in New York City was removed from a hotel and placed in a museum. Which is the correct place for things that society has decided it no longer needs, and which is the correct place to go to feel the specific grief of loss.

The kiosk is faster. The kiosk is free. The kiosk is always available. The kiosk knows your phone was near it at 11:47am on a Tuesday in March.



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SMALL GRID THEORY

— S. REYES

SMALL GRID THEORY

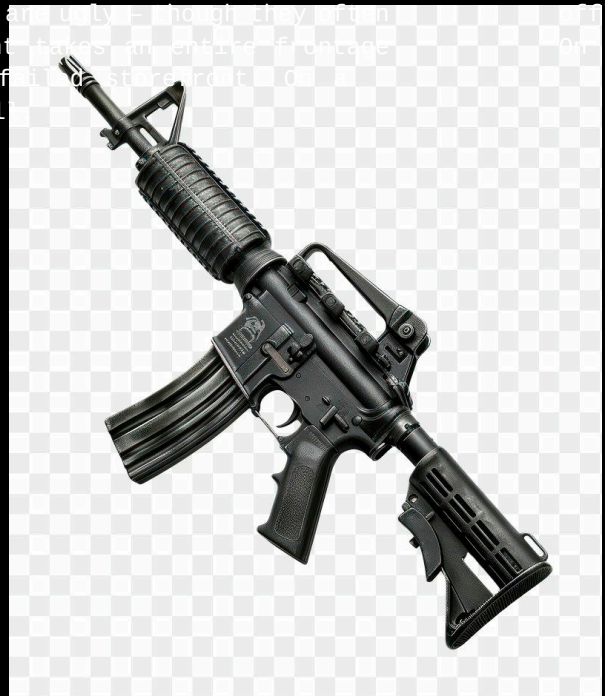
— S. REYES



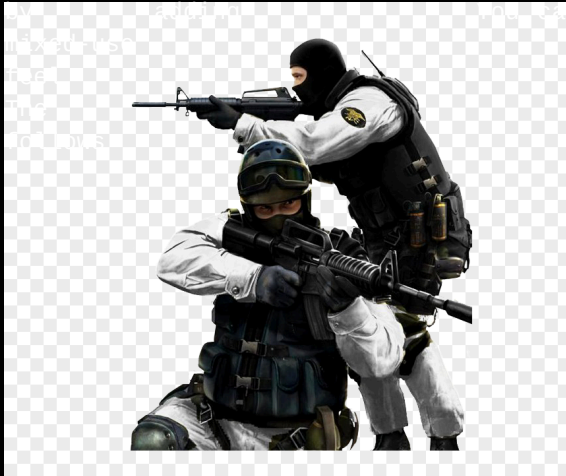
The most livable neighborhoods in most cities share one physical characteristic that urban planners consistently undervalue: **small blocks**. Not “walkable” in the sense of having sidewalks. Not “mixed-use” in the sense of having a Starbucks on the ground floor of a condo tower. Small blocks. Short distances between intersections. Many choices per square mile. The reason small blocks win is not aesthetic. It is combinatorial. A grid of small blocks offers exponentially more route choices than a grid of large blocks in the same area. More route choices means more foot traffic. More foot traffic means more storefronts. More storefronts means more activity.

“/ “SMALL BLOCK GRID, CENTRAL DISTRICT

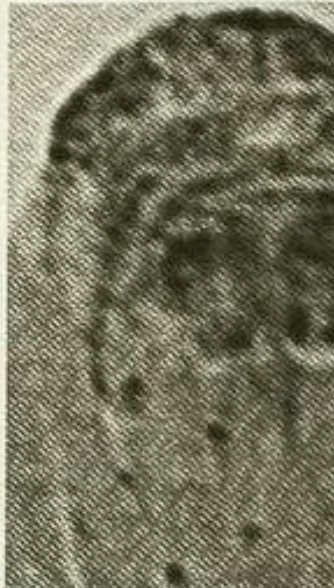
Large blocks produce dead zones. Not because they are empty — though they often are — but because a single failed anchor tenant leaves an entire block dead. In a small block, one failed storefront is one failed storefront. In a superblock, it is four hundred feet of blank wall.



Density is not the variable.
Granularity is the variable.



cannot retrofit walkability onto a large-block grid zoning. You can add a coffee shop on the ground floor of a 700-foot-frontage building and it will look like a coffee shop in an airport. Because it is. Blocks have to be small first. Everything else comes from the blocks. Jane Jacobs said this in 1961. We have spent sixty years building the opposite.



TENANCE WORKERS

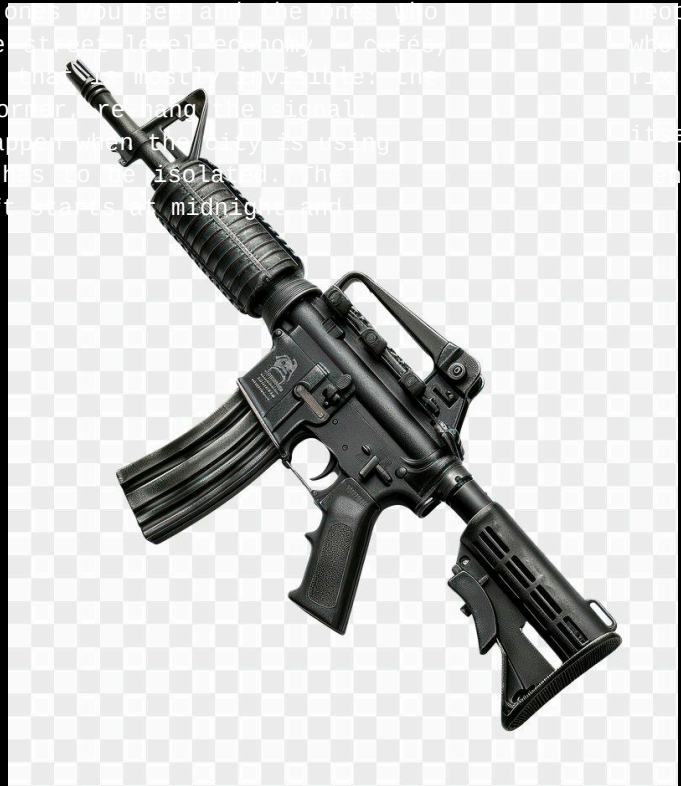
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— 038

THE MAINTENANCE WORKERS

— P. VOSS

Every city has two kinds of workers. The ones you see and the ones who make it possible for you to see them. The first is the ideal economy – coffee, shops, deliveries – depends on a substrate that will stay invisible: the pipes, patch the road, swap the transformer core, and the ideal. They work at 2am because the work cannot happen when the city is using itself. The road has to be empty. The water main has to be isolated. The substation has to be de-energized. The shift starts at midnight and ends before anyone notices it happened.



"/ "SUBSTATION CREW, 2:30AM



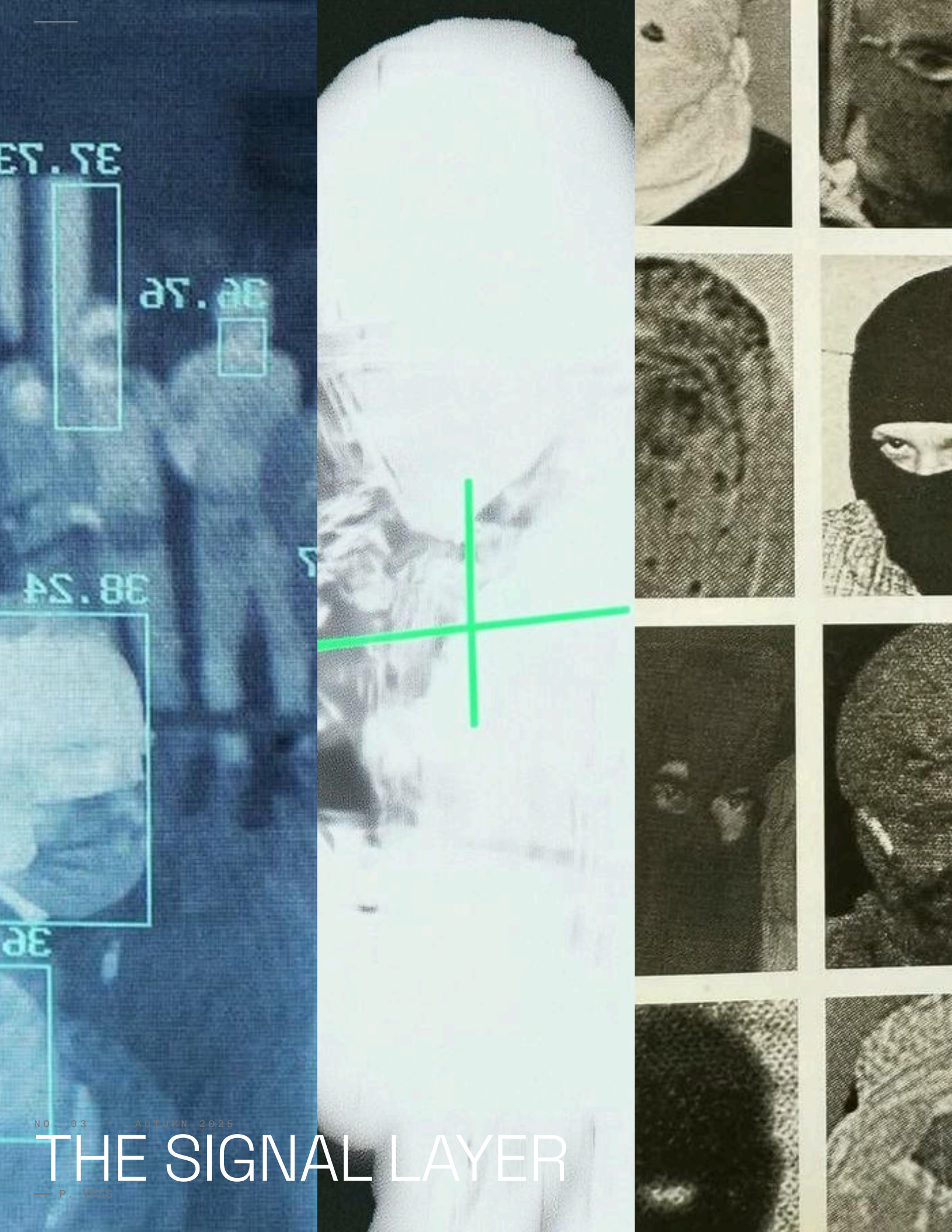
It is by design. The ideal maintenance event is one that no one knows occurred. The pipe doesn't burst, so there's no story. The signal doesn't fail, so there's no backup. The transformer holds, so the hospital stays on.

INVISIBILITY AS SUCCESS METRIC

The KPI for infrastructure maintenance is the absence of events. Nothing happened. That is the goal. That is how you know it worked.

built an economy around visibility – metrics, impressions. And then we have built the physical world for people whose best outcome is that you never think about them at all.





37.78

38.78

38.78

38

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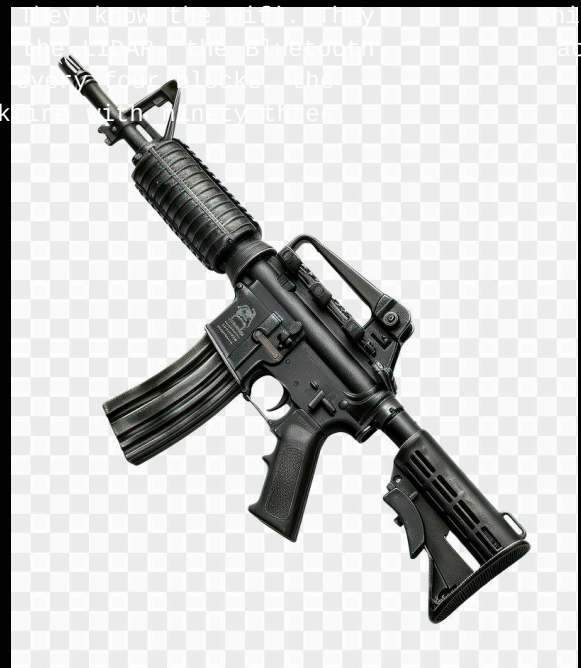
THE SIGNAL LAYER

— P. VOSS



The final layer is where the city becomes legible to the buses are just buses. With it, the buses are a dataset. The streets are a dataset. The pedestrians are The city reads itself continuously and the reading does.

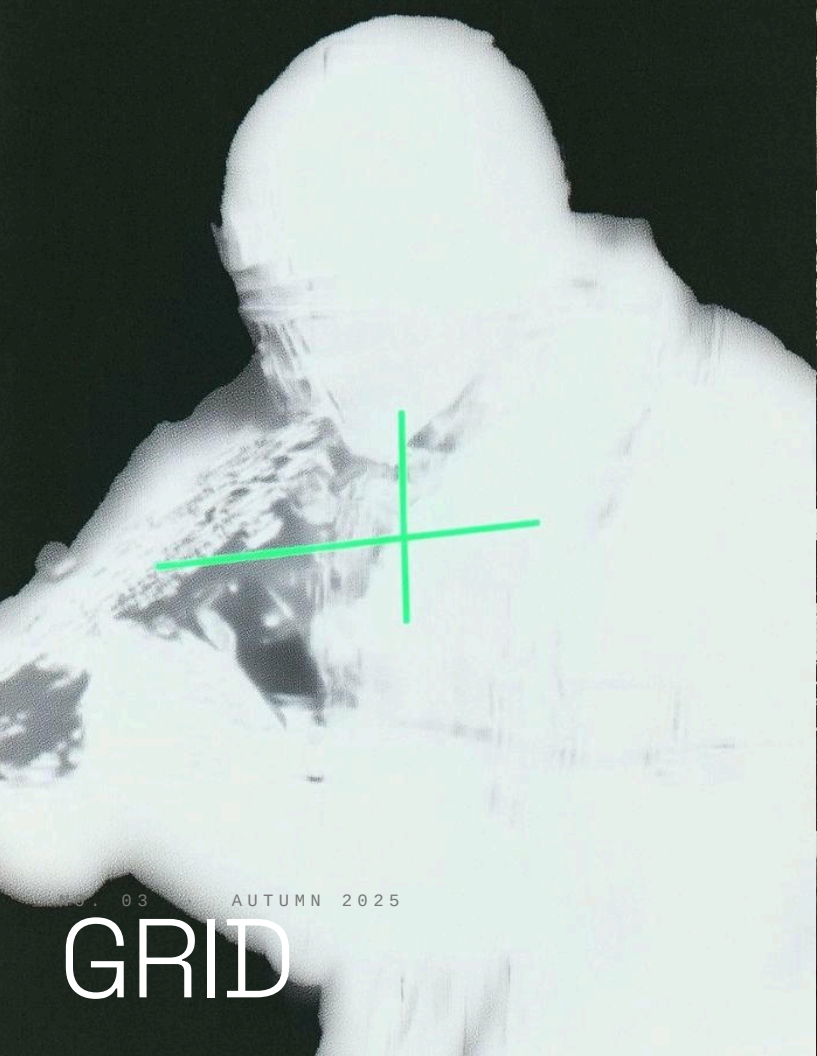

 I know the diff. they
 have in the Bluetooth
 and the acoustic
 diff. in my life

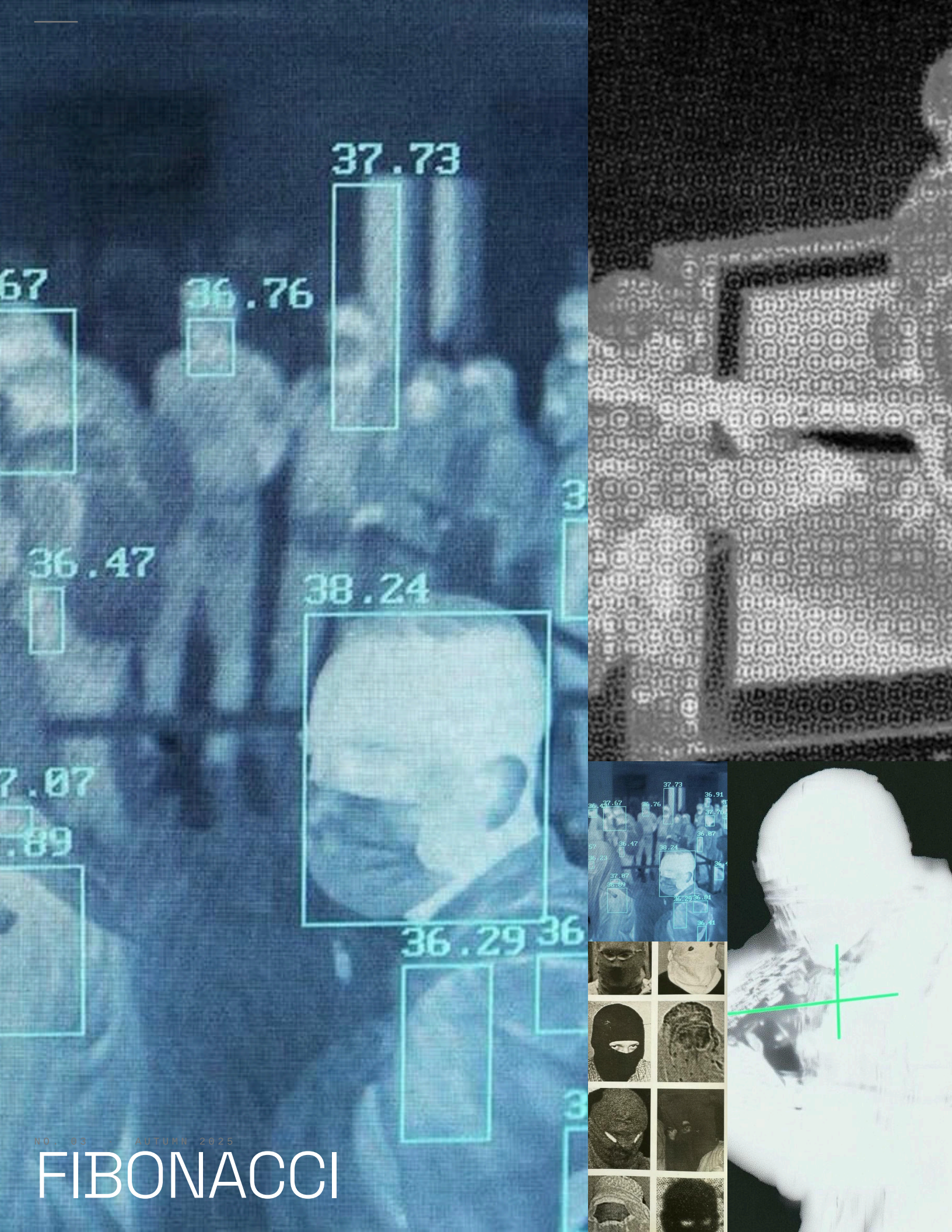


Where you were. How fast you moved. What device you carried. Whether you stopped. For how long. Whether you stopped at that spot before.

A photograph of two police officers in tactical gear. The officer in the foreground is wearing a helmet with a visor and is aiming a rifle. The officer behind him is also in tactical gear, including a balaclava, and is aiming a rifle. Both are wearing vests with pouches. The background is a plain, light-colored wall.

Signal layer does not forget. The buses forget. The layer keeps a log.





37.73

67

36.76

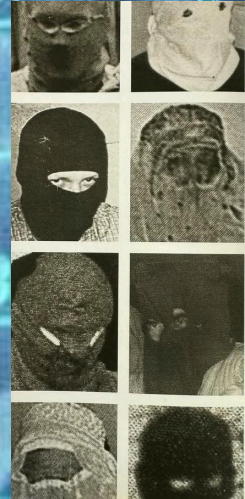
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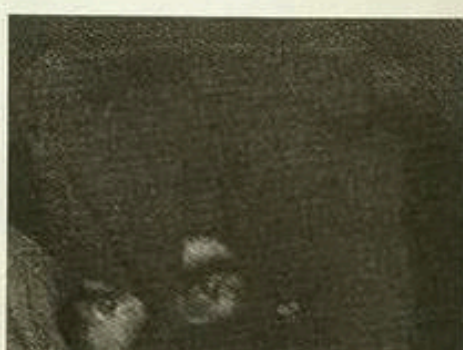
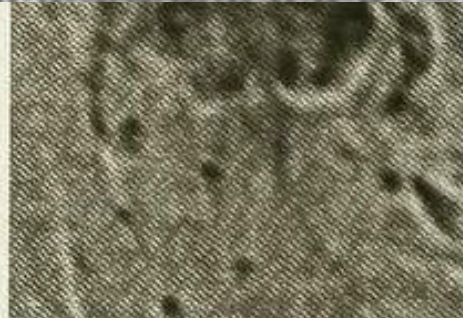
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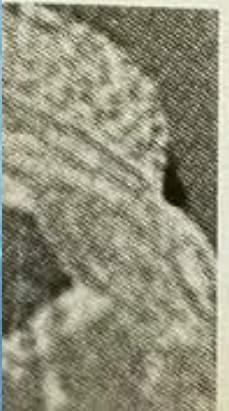
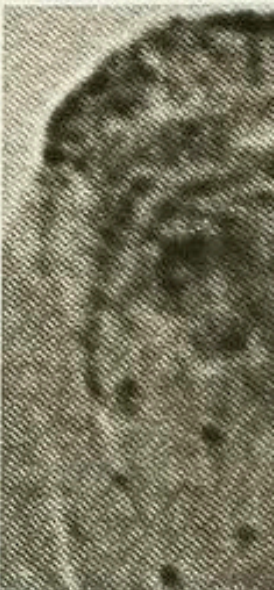
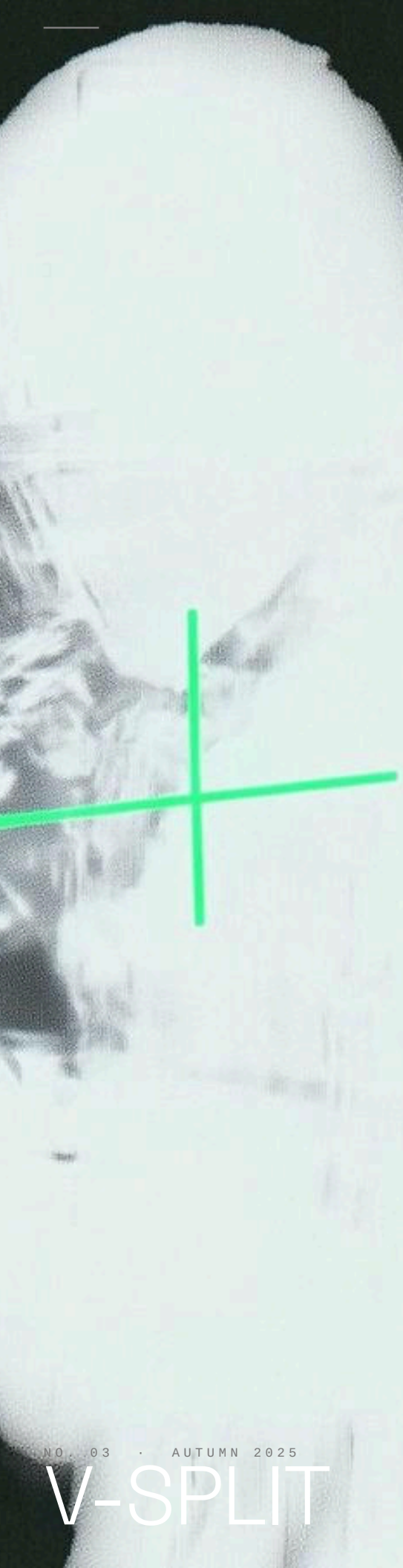
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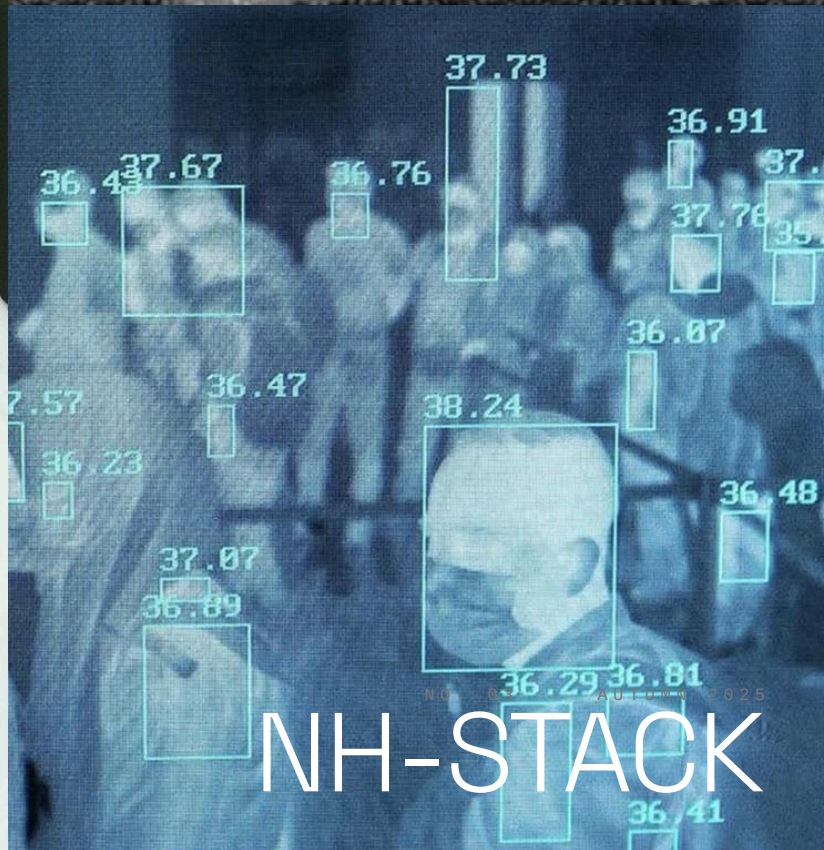
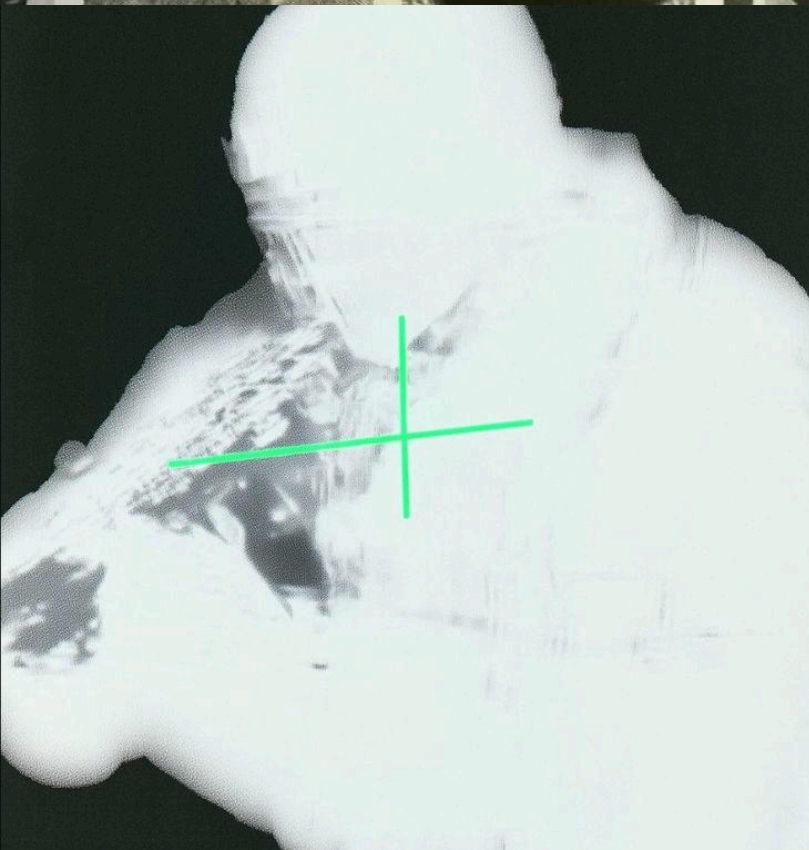
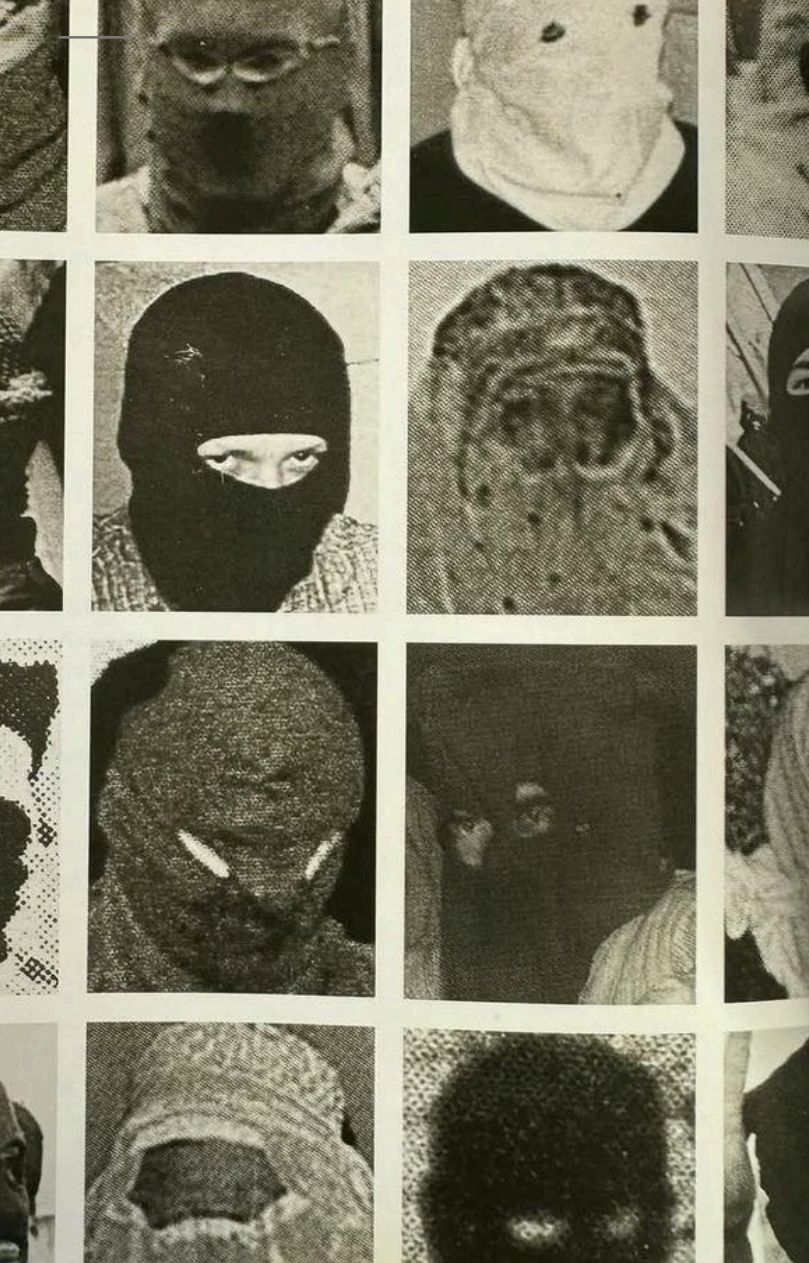


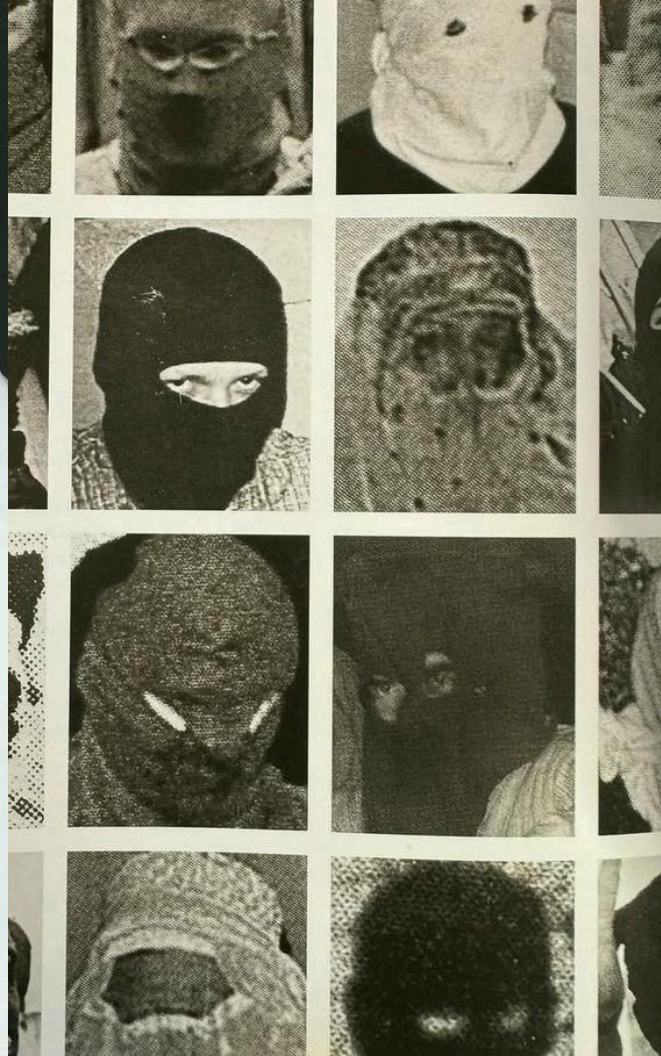


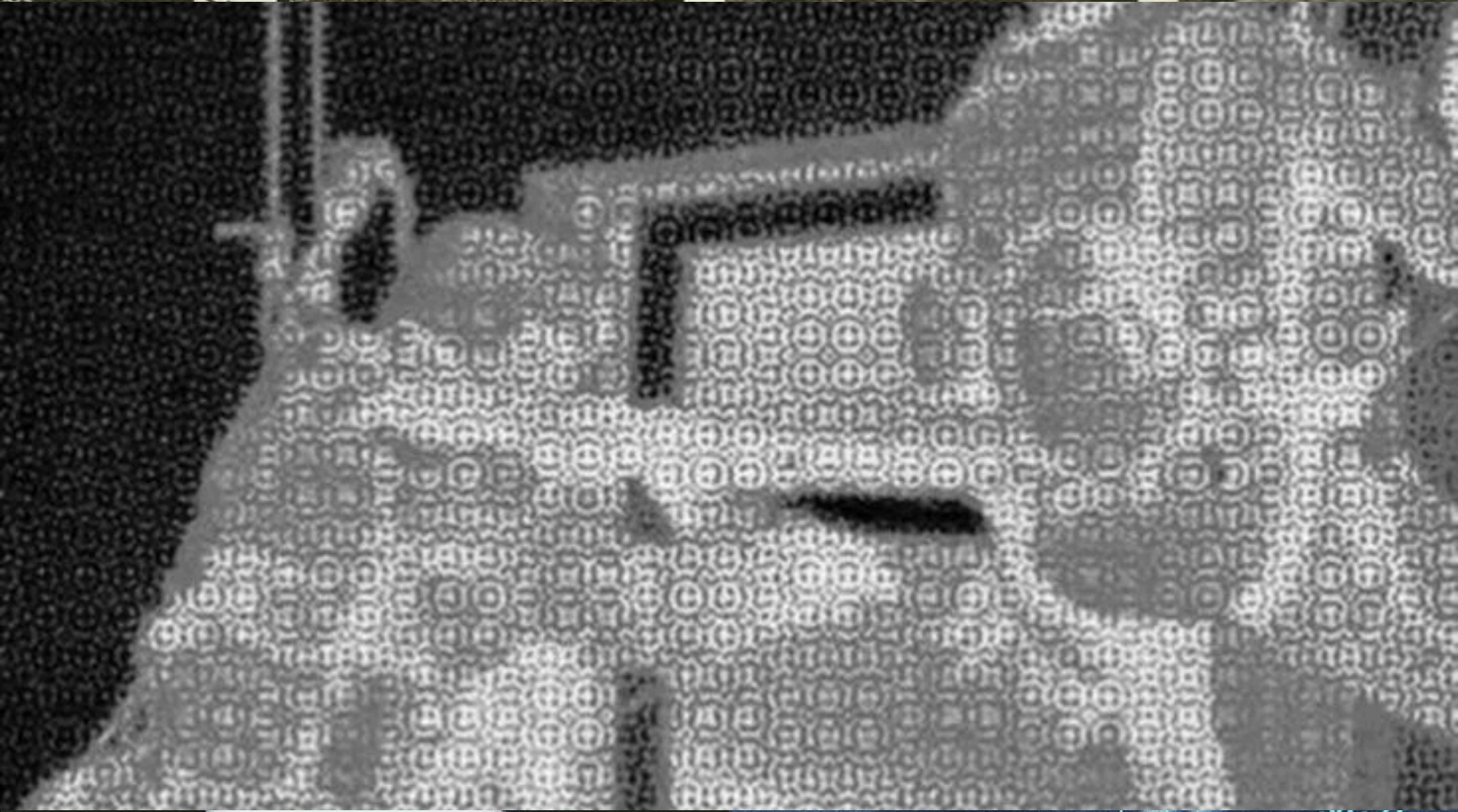
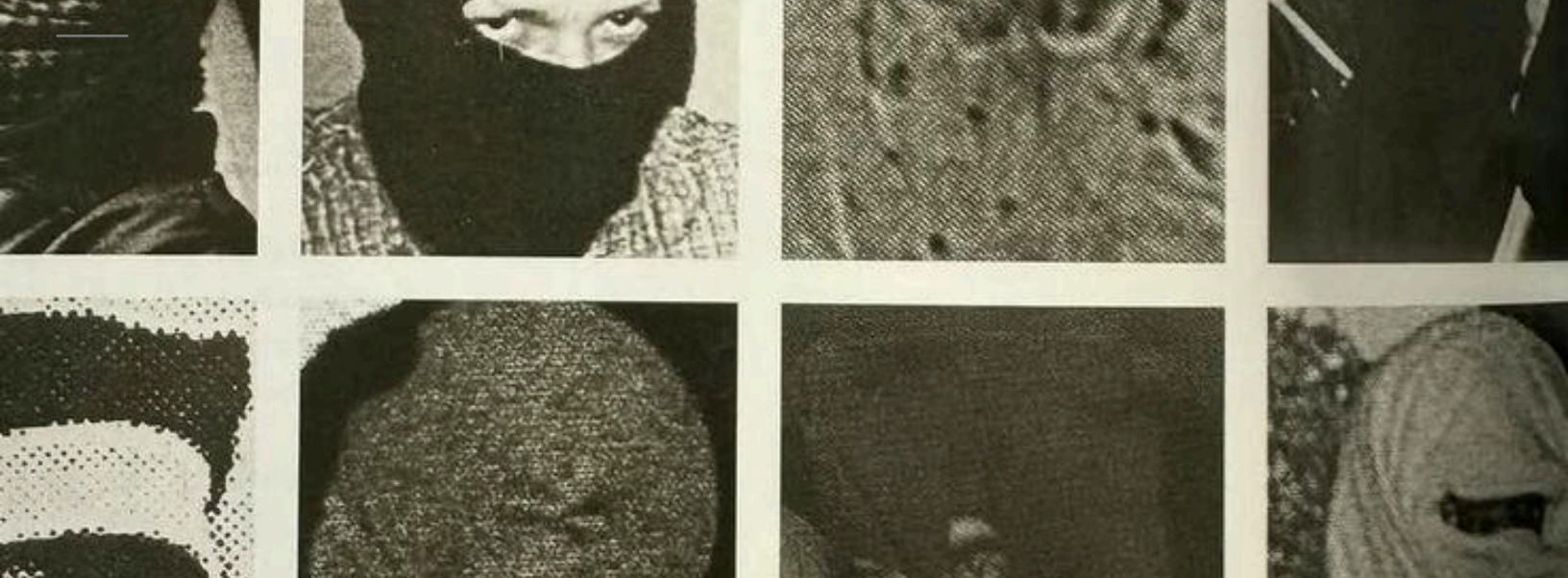
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H-SPLIT



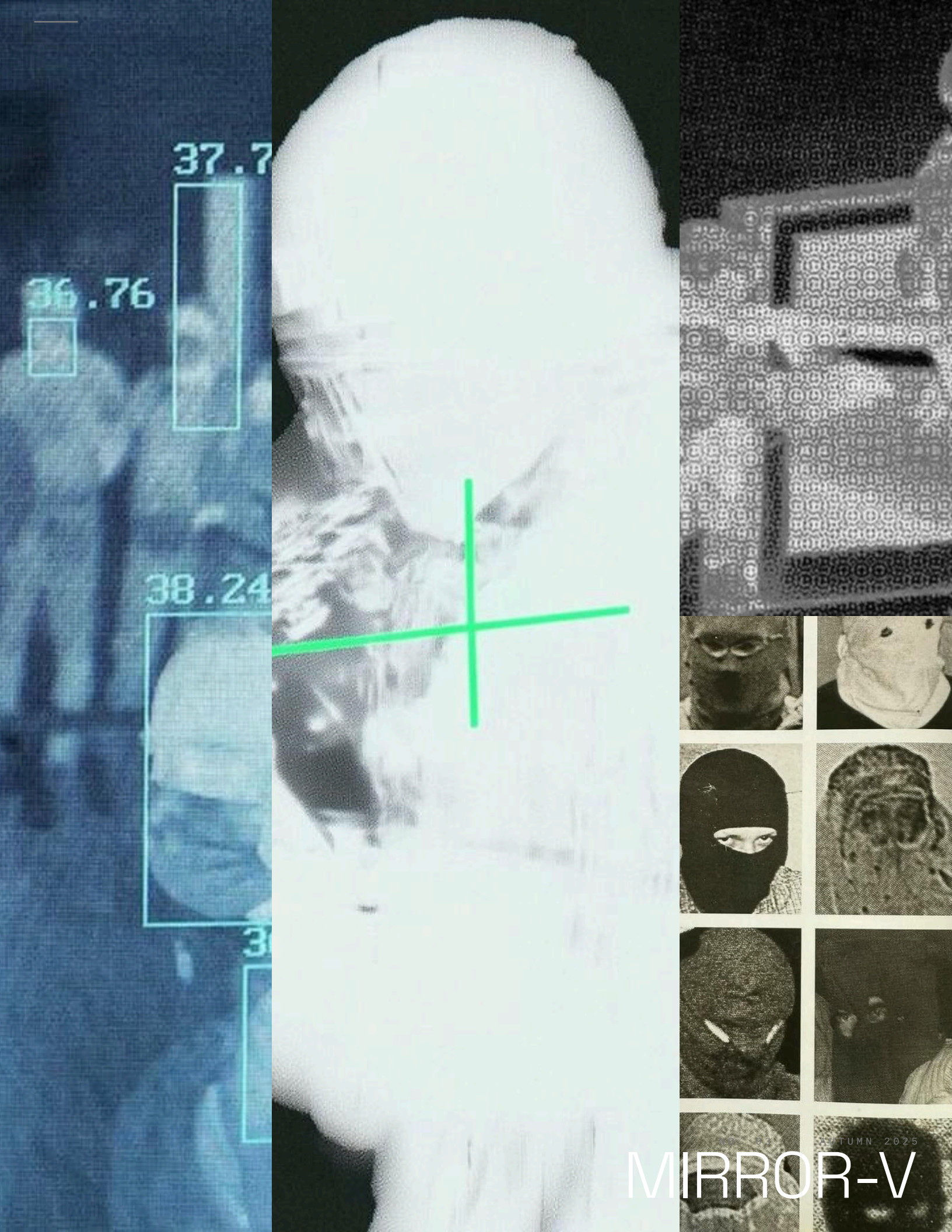






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MIRROR-H



36.76

37.7

38.24

3

MIRROR-V

TUMN 2025

ON THE BUS PIECE (ISSUE 02) ____

You said the bus is slow because of choices, not physics. I've been thinking about this for three weeks. You're right and I hate it. — **J.W., Chicago**

CORRECTION ____

The Houston light rail does not go to the airport. We stated that it did. It does not. We regret this. — **the editors**

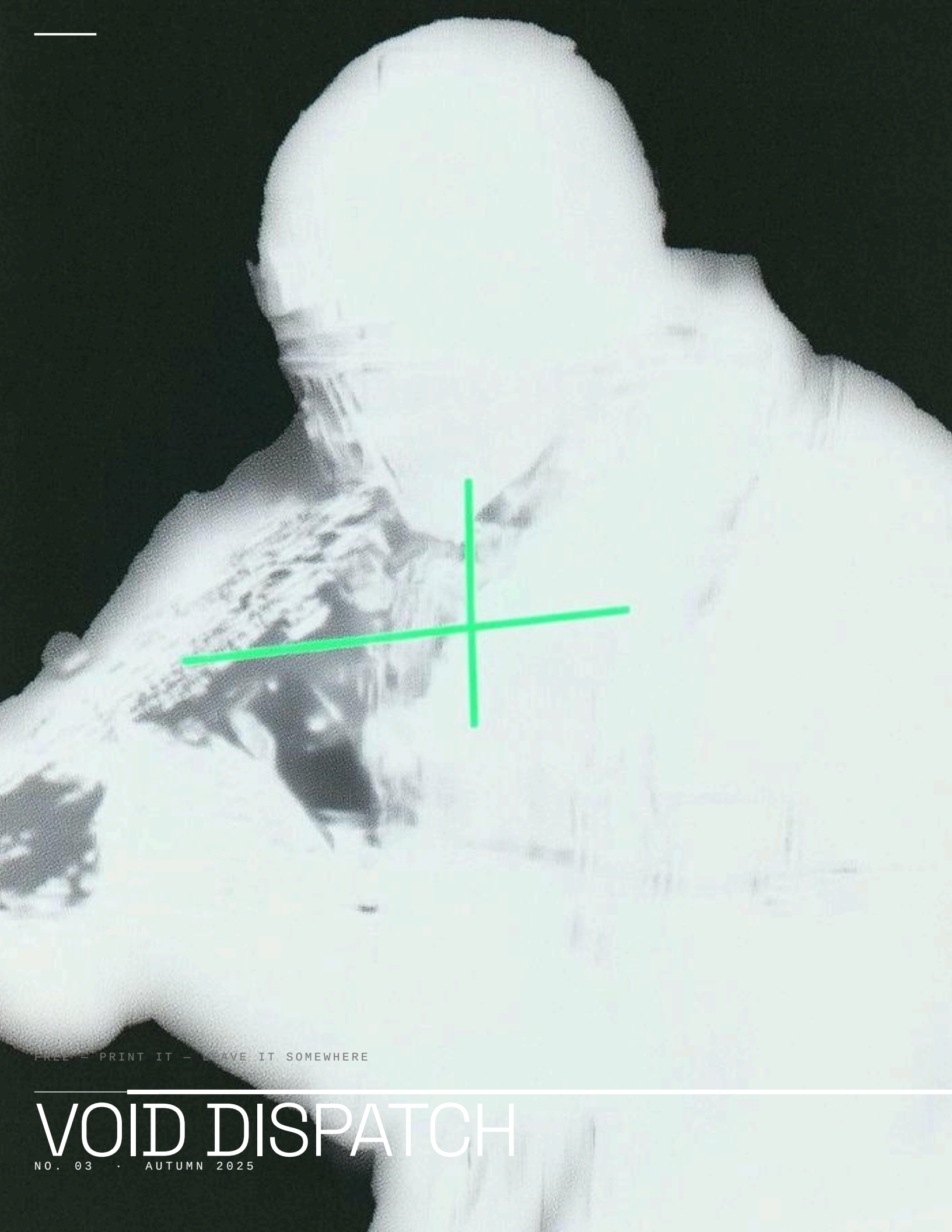
SUBMISSIONS ____

800 words or fewer. No pitches. Send it done. Plaintext. — **void-dispatch@proton.me**

Next issue: infrastructure that fights back. Submissions open. 800 words or fewer. No pitches. Send it done.

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